Literature on Media Coverage of Incumbents

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1 How the Media Covers Incumbents

1.1 Democracies and Cross National Studies

There is a wide range of research examining how medias in democracies, which are broadly assumed to operate with a high degree of freedom from government interference, cover incumbents. The core findings identify a tension between an incumbency bonus, where incumbents tend to get a greater quantity of coverage, and an incumbency burden, where market incentives push reporting towards coverage of negative events and tone. At a baseline, Hallin and Mancini (2004) provide a comparison of media systems in Western Europe and North America to explain why press-government relations differ across countries, justifying an expectation of varying media coverage of incumbents event across democratic states. Instead, the relationship between journalists and those in power should vary with the political and media-market structures of each country.

Several studies explain why incumbents dominate media coverage. Using Danish election coverage, Hopmann et al. (2011) test whether the incumbency bonus is driven by the distribution of political power or by the media market. They find that the more unevenly political power is distributed, the more visible the government is in media coverage. Vos and Van Aelst (2018) extend this political-system logic cross-nationally with a large-scale content analysis of television, newspaper, and online news in sixteen democracies (14 European countries along with Israel and the United States). In countries

where political power is more equally distributed across politicians, a broader range of elite politicians make it into the news.

Green-Pedersen et al. (2017) examine the incumbency bonus and challenge the assumption that media dominance is an electoral asset. They argue against coverage allocation simply reflecting political power, instead positing that political reporting outside election campaigns is driven by the watchdog norm. Because incumbents in democracies are held responsible for all kinds of societal problems, their prominence in the news is closely tied to bad news. During campaigns, by contrast, a balanced treatment of the electoral contest makes challengers more newsworthy, so the incumbency bonus should decline. Consistent with this account, they find that incumbent support declines as incumbents' media appearances increase, whereas media prominence does not hurt the opposition. Thesen et al. (2024) further develop this argument into a cross-national account of the "cost of ruling," the well-documented tendency of incumbents to lose support at the next election. They argue that the incumbency bonus in the quantity of coverage hides a burden of bad news. They find that media coverage involving incumbents is systematically and cross-nationally more negative than coverage involving the opposition, and that variation in this incumbency burden contributes substantially to predictions of government support. Their work therefore links incumbent coverage directly to citizen evaluations of government.

This pattern of accuracy combined with negativity in media coverage of incumbents in democracies is also observed in coverage of the economy. Kayser and Peress (2021) assemble the first large-scale cross-national dataset of economic news: over two million articles on growth, unemployment, and inflation from 32 mainstream newspapers (one left-wing and one right-wing across 16 developed democracies). They find that the tone of most mainstream newspapers tracks the economy faithfully, but that the frequency of coverage increases with negative outcomes. They find some evidence of partisan bias in the tone of growth headlines and in the frequency of unemployment coverage, but its substantive magnitude is very small.

Importantly, there are also challenges to measuring and characterizing media cover-

age on a broader scale. Hopmann et al. (2012) examine how the concept of "balance" is notoriously difficult to operationalize and has usually been studied through the issues raised in elections and through the volume and favorability of coverage of political actors. Drawing on prior research in Western democracies, they distinguish a *political system* perspective, in which coverage reflects politically defined norms or regulation, from a *media routine* perspective, in which coverage results from journalistic norms. They conclude that Western broadcasting, unless forced to follow norms, tends to follow a media routine logic, while newspaper coverage is sometimes imbalanced under both perspectives. They also argue that only systematic analysis across time and space can establish whether "imbalanced" news reflects partisan bias.

1.2 Captured Media and Government Influence on Incumbent Reporting

Alternatively, where governments can more directly influence media owners or control outlets, dynamics surrounding media coverage of incumbents change. Rather than mainly reflecting journalistic norms, coverage of the incumbent becomes something the government actively shapes. Di Tella and Franceschelli (2011) measure front-page coverage of government corruption scandals in Argentina's four main newspapers from 1998 to 2007 and find that increases in government advertising in a newspaper are associated with reductions in that newspaper's coverage of corruption scandals. In a similar case, Szeidl and Szucs (2021) use data from Hungary to document advertising favors from the government to connected media and, in return, corruption-coverage favors from connected media to the government. Their empirical strategy exploits sharp reallocations around changes in media ownership to rule out market-based explanations. Using a structural model, they find that both owner ideology and favor exchange drive these favors. They conclude that targeted government advertising can meaningfully influence content, and that it can also shape owner ideology by making media ownership more profitable for pro-government investors. Where governments have the ability to influence media coverage, they will do so in their own favor.

In autocratic contexts, incumbents are particularly well situated and well motivated to manage coverage of themselves. Lawson (2002), although primarily focused on how media liberalization and democratization were mutually reinforcing, also clearly demonstrates how state capture of media operated. In pre-democratic Mexcio, the consequences of media corruption and censorship of news coverage on news reporting were centralized partisan bias in favor of the ruling party and selective silence on sensitive issues for the regime. Guriev and Treisman (2022) argue that many contemporary authoritarian rulers are "spin dictators." Instead of relying on mass violence, these rulers hold power by manipulating information, co-opting the media, and simulating democratic procedures, and they cultivate an image of competence while concealing censorship. Rozenas and Stukal (2019) provide systematic evidence of one such strategy. Using a large corpus of daily news reports from three national television channels in Russia from 2000 to 2016, they find no evidence of simple fact-censorship: negative and positive economic events are reported at very similar rates. Instead, state television assigns responsibility selectively. Negative economic news is more likely to implicate external factors, especially global economic processes and Western governments, whereas positive news is more likely to implicate the domestic government, especially the president.

Autocrats do not always suppress independent coverage entirely, and could strategically enable incumbent reporting for the sake of improving performance in the long run. Egorov et al. (2009) develop a theory in which free media allow a dictator to monitor and discipline bureaucrats and thereby improve the quality of government. Because this benefit matters less when a dictator has natural resource rents, media freedom is less likely to emerge in resource-rich countries. Consistent with the theory, they show with panel data that, controlling for country fixed effects, media are less free in oil-rich economies, especially in nondemocratic regimes. Lorentzen (2014) similarly produces a formal model demonstrating that under some conditions, a regime optimally permits investigative reporting on lower-level officialdom, adjusting how much reporting is allowed depending on the level of underlying social tensions.

2 Impact of Incumbent Coverage on Citizen Attitudes

2.1 Democracies

If coverage is accurate but negatively biased, as the work above suggests, we should expect it to hurt incumbents. Garz and Martin (2021) show that when U.S. state unemployment rates cross a round-number "milestone," newspaper coverage of unemployment jumps discontinuously even though underlying economic conditions are nearly identical. Using this discontinuity, they estimate the effect of attention to unemployment news on incumbent U.S. governors' vote shares while holding actual economic conditions constant. The effects are asymmetric: bad milestones hurt incumbents roughly twice as much as good milestones help them. These findings suggest that media coverage in democracies should therefore capable of enforcing electoral accountability through their editorial decisions about which issues to emphasize.

The effect of coverage may also depend on the medium and on who is consuming it. Studying the expansion of television in the United States, Prior (2006) shows that the growth of television contributed to the rise in the incumbency advantage in U.S. House elections during the 1960s. The effect was concentrated among less-educated voters, for whom television offered a new, less demanding source of news. In districts with television stations, less-educated respondents were more knowledgeable about the incumbent and more likely to vote for the incumbent. Unlike the incumbency burden documented in more recent European news, then, the visibility that early local television gave incumbents worked to their advantage, especially among less-educated citizens.

In democracies outside the U.S. Hopmann et al. (2010) show for Denmark that both the visibility and the tone of election coverage shift party choice. The more visible a party is, and the more positive the tone toward it, the more voters are inclined to vote for it. This work suggests that visibility does help parties when coverage is favorable. Because incumbents' visibility comes disproportionately through negative, responsibility-laden news, however, their media prominence tends to coincide with declining support.

2.2 Autocracies

In literature concerning the consequences of media coverage in autocracies, the question shifts from how independent coverage affects incumbents to whether regime-controlled coverage of the incumbent changes citizen attitudes and behavior. Government influence in media coverage influences citizens in a variety of ways. Huang (2015) argues that authoritarian governments often use propaganda not to indoctrinate citizens with pro-government attitudes but to signal the regime's strength in maintaining social control and political order. Using survey data from China, he finds that college students with more exposure to state propaganda, in the form of ideological and political education, are not more satisfied with the government system. They are, however, more likely to believe that the regime is strong in maintaining social control and less willing to participate in political dissent. These consequences can also be observed in political behavior outcomes. Drawing on an original dataset of over four million articles from state-run newspapers in thirty countries and six languages, Carter and Carter (2021) find that propaganda reduces the rate of popular protest in autocracies and that its effects persist over time. Increasing pro-regime propaganda by one standard deviation reduces the odds of protest the following day by 15%. Alternatively, government influence on media coverage make take the form of emotional persuasion through "soft" propaganda. Mattingly and Yao (2022) expose respondents in China to propaganda videos drawn from state-run newscasts, television dramas, and state-backed social media accounts, each containing nationalist messages favored by the Chinese Communist Party. Their work shows how propaganda that does not look like conventional political messaging can work through emotional appeals tied to nationalism.

3 Media Coverage of Corruption

Corruption is the domain in which the link between coverage of incumbents and citizen responses has been studied most directly. The literature reviewed here suggests that voters do punish revealed corruption, but only under certain conditions. The information

has to reach voters, which depends on whether and how much outlets cover it. Partisanship can blunt voters' reactions, while outlets' willingness to cover corruption is shaped by government advertising, ownership ties, and the legal environment.

Coverage itself is a central condition for electoral punishment. Costas-Pérez et al. (2012) build a database of corruption scandals affecting Spanish local governments between 1996 and 2009, including information on press coverage of each scandal and on judicial intervention as reported in the press. They find that voters punish corrupt mayors with an average vote loss of around 4%. The punishment is greater for cases that receive wide newspaper attention (up to 9%), and scandals with both judicial charges and wide press coverage produce the largest vote loss (14%). They find no vote loss at all in cases that were dismissed or that did not lead to further judicial intervention. They interpret these results as showing that press information changes voters' beliefs about the prevalence of corruption and helps them distinguish founded from unfounded allegations.

Whether such coverage appears at all depends on the media environment. Stanig (2015) studies local newspapers across Mexican states and shows that the legal regulation of speech affects how newspapers report sensitive political information. Many articles on corruption are "missing" from newspapers in states with more punitive defamation laws, so restrictions on media freedom reduce corruption coverage. The capture studies discussed above point in the same direction. Government advertising in Argentina is associated with less front-page coverage of government corruption scandals (Di Tella & Franceschelli, 2011), and in Hungary connected media returned advertising favors with favorable corruption coverage (Szeidl & Szucs, 2021). Together these studies show that the information on which electoral punishment of corruption depends is itself vulnerable to government influence.

Even when corruption is covered, voters may not respond uniformly. Anduiza et al. (2013) ask why corruption does not seem to have the electoral consequences we would expect. In a survey experiment in Spain, they show that the same offense is judged differently depending on whether the responsible politician belongs to the respondent's party, to a rival party, or has no stated party affiliation. Partisans are more tolerant

of corruption committed by their own party. The degree of partisan bias depends on political sophistication, however, and the bias disappears among those with high political awareness. Coverage of a corrupt incumbent is therefore filtered through partisanship before it shapes attitudes.

4 Media Coverage of Repression

Research on repression engages with media coverage in a variety of ways. Repression influences what the media actually covers while media coverage also potentially deincentivizes repression through watchdog reporting. Whitten-Woodring and James (2012) develop a formal model of how the news media, citizens, and the government interact in the repression-protest nexus. They argue that media independence and democratic characteristics, especially political competition, substantially affect government repression because they determine how vulnerable a government is to public pressure. Their model consists of three equations: one for whether the media perform a "watchdog" role regarding government repression, one for protest, and one for government repression. They solve it for four scenarios, evaluating the presence or absence of democracy against the presence or absence of media independence, finding that in the autocracy-without-independent-media scenario, watchdogging is at a minimum, protest is relatively low and repression is at a maximum.

How the media and the regime describe protest shapes public tolerance for repression. Arnon et al. (2023) study strategic labeling and public statements by regime sources in response to protest, an often-overlooked form of information control. In a survey experiment in China that labels environmental protests, they find that accusatory labels portraying protesters as violent criminals increase support for repressing the protests. Regime sources, however, have no advantage over non-governmental sources in shifting opinion. In this context, the content of the label matters more than who delivers it. Conversely, media coverage that includes competing narratives about state violence can move citizen opinions in the other direction. González and Skigin (2026) examine how the

narratives used in coverage of police killings shape support for police violence in Brazil. In a nationwide survey experiment, they find that a police narrative criminalizing the victim and justifying the killing as self-defense increases endorsement of police violence. Counternarratives from victims' mothers emphasizing the victim's innocence or the disadvantage tied to race and class, however, can override the effects of the police narrative and reduce support. Whether coverage of state violence produces backlash therefore depends heavily on how that violence is framed, something that is likely influenced by the degree of government influence on media coverage.

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